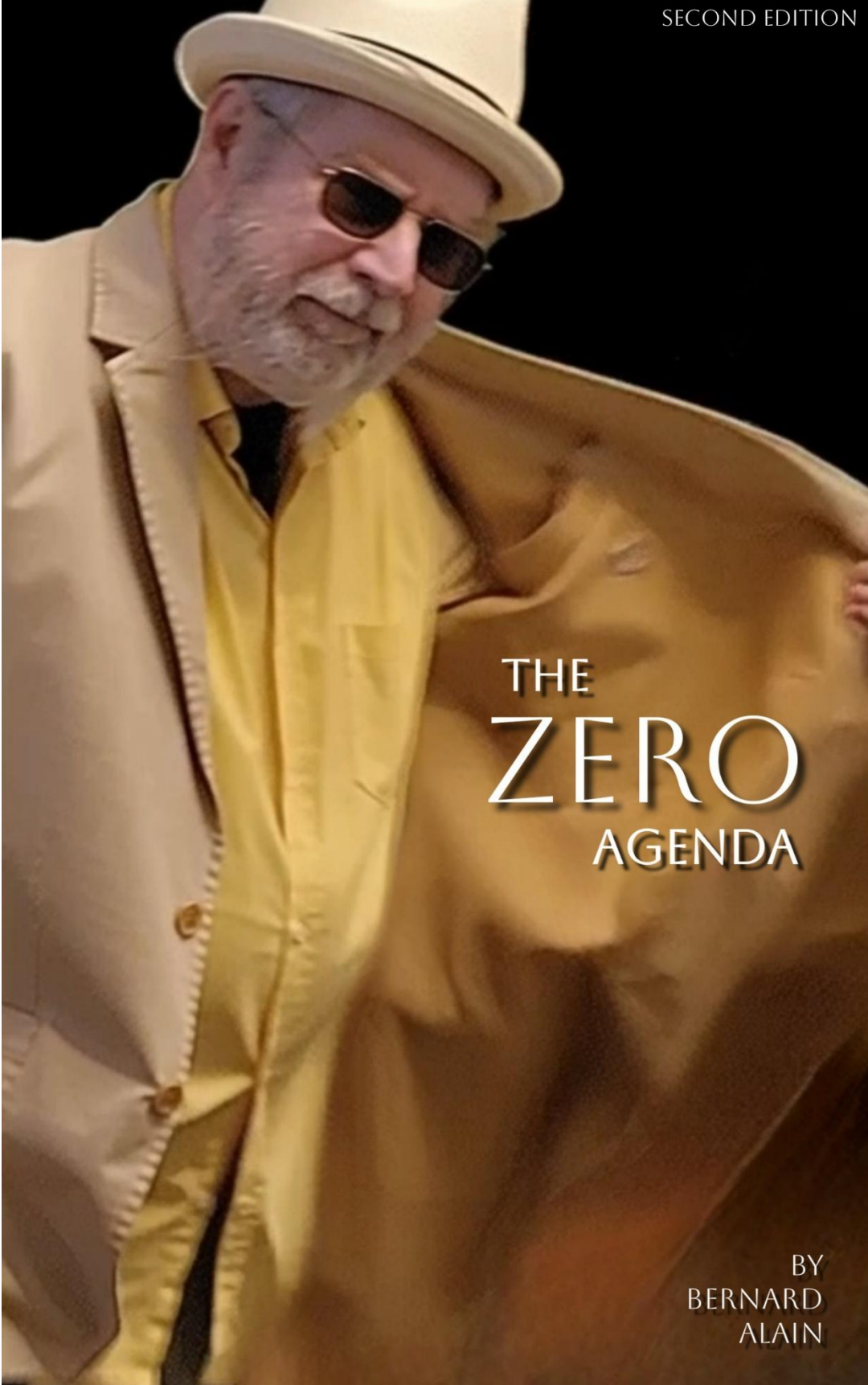




SECOND EDITION

THE
ZERO
AGENDA

BY
BERNARD
ALAIN

The poems in this edition represent an early selection from The Zero Agenda, an ongoing series.

Additional poems and updated editions will be released periodically.

Thank you for reading.

The Zero Agenda

by Bernard Alain

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Ottawa, Ontario, Canada.

Anthology Website:
bernardalain.github.io/TheZeroAgenda/

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Framing Eden

In May toward the end.

8:00 a.m. on a Sunday / the sill

Today, there is no departure.

Only tendrils reaching into the morning sun.

Both the cacti and the birds of paradise

died an early death this year—

The dracaena of course surviving neglect.

Some stubborn sense of purpose.

The gaps between the slats

let in only the most opulent of blue-eyes—

viridity

a tenacious insider.

Pulling Teeth

Later in March sometime.

8:06 a.m. on a Monday / rot.

Belvedere Avenue has two exits:

at the top & to the left—

for golfers and grandchildren,

at the bottom & to the right—

for everything else.

Today—the dentist.

I turn right.

The Ottawa River slowly reconnects

between the trees.

They moved the fishing shack with a huge

Canadian flag painted on its side—off thin ice,

onto some soggy extension.

The traffic up ahead reduced to one lane.

My foot never completely off the brake.

The pears from Portugal—fermenting

in the elastic cargo net as the strait fills up.

Finally,

a construction worker

wearing a yellow safety vest

flips the paddle from stop to slow.

I pass—lock eyes.

Open—

for the moment.

Total Compliance

In May sometime.

6:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / drips & drops

Belvedere Avenue has only one exit,
at the bottom & to the right—

No straddling the back nine.

No fancy pastry.

Just coconut oil and cinnamon drops—

I pass the community water supply pumps—
double back.

The taps are down to a trickle in Rockland.

A two cup day maybe—
one for the plants,
one for a strong coffee.

I arrive at the top of the hill.
A bit of sweat.

sustainable.

The Third Man Factor

Later in May sometime.

5:30 a.m. on a Tuesday / dropping kPa

I turn right with a quick left in mind.

My strides are brisk.

I could break into a jog.

Leap ahead.

DNA Automotive—

the Jehovah's Witness complex—

disappear behind me.

The kid on the hi-tech scooter overtakes the jogger.

The jogger and the dog overtake me.

Plugged ears—

Shortened breath—

The barometer—

Kilimanjaro comes to mind.

—that and the little man.

The Circle Game

Later in April sometime.

6:34 a.m. Monday / wet

Today, I only make it as far as the curb on
Belvedere Avenue.

A patch of dandelions forming on the easement.

No evidence of the blue-eyes.

A small gang of dogs out sniffing 'o'.

The shih poos and the russells
never seem to settle.

A Following

In April sometime.

7:30 a.m. on a Saturday / howler

I chase the brouhaha.

It was the love mud.

The extra coat—from the car wash puddle
at the bottom of the street.

possibly the same bad boys
that flattened the rose bush.

Front Yard Critic

Early in June sometime.

10:00 a.m. on a Saturday / doggie style

Off to get some groceries.

Mike across the way is working on his truck.

The shih poo is off the leash again.

He runs across three front lawns.

Plows through the hyacinths.

Arrives at my toes

with his hair done up in a pink bow

and a flip-flop in his mouth.

Says nothing.

The Herd

In April sometime.

11:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / off-ramps

I turn right onto March Road—
the first exit after the last Moodie turn-off sign—
en route to the docs.

The parking spots in front of the clinic
only appear to be tight.

OGs prefer the common cold.

Today, I manage to get out of the left lane
unscathed—turning on the yellow.

The Outcropping

Later in May sometime.

7:41 a.m. on a Tuesday / schizo

Belvedere Avenue has one exit—
at the bottom & to the right.

I deviate.

A small unmarked park just after
Laurier Avenue on Caron.

The tall grass between
the construction aggregate—almost
a herbarium /
the misfits—

A nameless rider
wearing Prada shades passes by
on a scooter.

Eastbound & westbound—
bumper to bumper.

Daytime lights still on.

Warm Front

Early in May sometime.

10:20 a.m. on a Saturday / semaphores

I turn right, follow the river's edge.

Today there are young kids out

on the aggregate

in brightly colored jackets—

holding corn dogs—no runners on.

A black-legged gull aloft—out early this year.

the westerlies perhaps.

Parallel Park

In April sometime.

10:15 a.m. on a Friday / the shoulder

Today I turn right—
towards St. Faustina's.

I am not a goer.

I am here for the extra left turn.

The parking lot is already full—

the extra spots just off the main drag.

Late as usual.

After the First Confession

Later in May.

8:06 a.m. on a Sunday / beam me up

Today—I return to St. Faustina's
for the milestones and the benefit of the doubt.

A procession emerges
from the heavy wooden doors.
Aspersions settling on the heads
of last month's lilies.
The communion complete—

my grandson beams.

Me,
saved by a Star Wars Mandalorian.
Lego—Ages 5+

Ten Hail Marys

Early in June sometime.

11:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / distillate

I travel past the last Moodie turn-off sign.

Turn on Wheeler—

Uphill into unimpeded blue.

The saloon leagues casually conspire
among the barn-gray mansards—like pirate ships
on a sea of green.

I pull into the laneway.

The husky is always barking.

Todd of course, would suck the bottle dry.

What didn't sing like Moon Harbor—stored
in mason jars behind the cellar door.

Low-Dose Alternatives

Later in May sometime.

9:21 a.m. on a Wednesday / strictly speaking

Off to the pharmacy.

I turn left on Laurier.

The radio bleats an aspirin endorsement.

More news on the oil tankers and the strait.

we are what we eat.

I pass the tailors on the left.

Pass by McDonald's.

I turn off the Hormuz updates—
one per day.

max.

The Morning Feed

Much later in December sometime.

10:35 a.m. on a Sunday / hitman

Today I turn right—land at Starbucks.

When I sliced through the
froth this morning it almost
looked like an olive leaf.

A moment I thought
then nah—just another swirl.

Soon to be consumed by
Paradiso and Breakfast
Blend.

And that's how I handle
the zombie attacks.
that—and the less friendly
button I push from time to time

—

for the sake of the right hemisphere—
and all of its indulgences.

Bling

Early in December sometime.

10:00 a.m. on a Saturday / some time after
the fluff

Today again, no departure—just the laundry.

I can hear the spin cycle finishing up
over the sound of the TV.

A rerun of The Fatman.

It ended here

then here

then nowhere—

but who am I to judge

hanging like an old sock.

hoping a match will jump out of the pile—

Mel can afford the maids.

Holiday Lineup

Later in May sometime.

6:05 a.m. on a Saturday / the morning after

Today I turn right—the cupboards bare.

I pass Timmy's—

pass Food Basics—

pull into A&W.

I can hear an engine purring behind the plate glass

as I wait in the line-up.

Someone in Ray Bans outside.

Balancing two cardboard trays and a set of keys

while trying to pry the car door open with his

knee.

same model—newer engine.

The Gamma Lama Ding Dong

In May sometime.

8:15 a.m. Thursday / articulator

Today I pick my car up from a garage in
Ottawa.

I taxi to Orleans then take the city bus.

And it's a lot like cooking turkey.

Towards the end something / someone
just might get burned.

Staying focused is everything.

And they've studied people sitting
with their eyes closed.

Simply watching their breath, with nothing
to look at and no task to react to.

In that calmer setting, a small dip
in fast brain activity leading
to less mind wandering.

Fewer distractions as attention steadies
over the first several minutes ...sh*t!

I missed my stop.

The Many Ways to Die

In May toward the end.

6:00 a.m. on a Sunday / Koi Pla, and the live red ants

Today, there is departure but only essence.

We imagine some other way of being.

Where what consumes us has legs and eyes,
but mostly feels—never thinks.

It's the lemon juice that would make me squint.

Though having never really known hunger.

They would surely die quietly when
swallowed—like leaves falling from a tree.

So many poisons—

Life too short to worry about what
might eat you up from the inside out.

Nothing like the tree in the forest,
and how it goes down.

Nevermind the flukes.

In the Words of O'Leary

Mid April

way after lunch on a Friday / at the wake

Her last words to me were

"you're irreverent."

Today she is right—

the living as far away as the dead.

Tardigrade

In May sometime.

dart night on a Thursday / pub fare

It's been a while since I've played, no less
the golden years, having become somewhat
resistant to bending over.

And I find it even harder to concentrate
with a ringer firing away at the adjacent dartboard.

John could suck the DNA right out of you on
any given day. He'd chew you to pieces, spit you
out in some other form and never tell you how
he did it.

He should be wearing a warning label so he
doesn't suck anybody dry on dart night:

one hundred and eighty
one hundred and eighty—over and over
all night long.

Wagonload

In October sometime.

Later on a Monday / the turnip run

I turn right onto the highway.

The truck up ahead, clanking like a
war-time jeep.

The produce in the rear—raw / exposed.

It's hard to tell what causes things to pop
the way they do.

A farmer would tell you it's the potholes that
tip the frame—squeeze the rutabagas out.

They just tumble down the shoulder
along with the near-do-wells.

Unaware that shadows don't answer—

they just disappear—

Somewhere between the afternoon show
and the sleepless night.

On Taming the Shrew

Later in April sometime.

10:16 a.m. on a Thursday / as if

I pass a staggered array
of ice shacks and idle punts—
pulled to the river's edge.

Bob in the blue pickup ahead of me—
en route to the big city.
"So much for Kentucky," he says.

The ripples,
an occasional white crest,
maybe an eyebrow lifting up
among the wavelets—

how undisturbed the riverscape.

Master of Dilation

Later in April

10:16 a.m. on a Thursday / the strait

Today I turn right—leaving Rockland.

Ahead the construction pylons are out—

the lane reduction has begun.

Traffic is down to a crawl.

I hit CNN on my console app—

apparently the Three Gorges Dam

built by the Chinese, lengthens a day

by 0.06 microseconds.

what do they know—

The No Free Lunch Policy

In April sometime.

10:45 a.m. on a Saturday / going numb

I turn right, the dentist.

The hygienist goes on about her nieces. Prying
at the sensitive areas from time to time—asking
if I feel anything.

The intake clerk fills out the balance
of my invoice—smiles.
I swipe.

the anesthesia already wearing off.

Sweet Surrender

Much later in December sometime.

10:05 a.m. on a Saturday / mall diastolic

I turn right—to St. Laurent Mall,
in search of a chocolatier—the last ditch for
schmoozers and lollygaggers like myself.

Chocolate, maple taffy

and sea salt.

High-end turtles maybe.

The Purdy salesclerk already leaning in.

A Toys "R" Us bag passes by, followed by a
small cadre of whining toddlers.

I eat it.

Overflow in Seasonals

Later in May sometime.

10:16 a.m. on a Saturday / the smaller arks

Today—en route to the Canadian Tire in Orleans.

The peninsulas along the way sunken from the
freshet flood.

The gulls appear to walk on water.

I pass St. Faustina's on the right.

Arrive at the mall.

The store parking is full.

Kayaks walking out—with four feet

and pairs of heads.

Francis and the Ferraris

Early in August sometime.

3:00 a.m. on a Monday / muggy

Another lid pops—rolls down the avenue.

A bit of late night noire.

Sure as hell it was those trash-dragging
opportunists—

Tipping barrels—

Nose in everyone's leavings—

Blessings to you—

and put a lid on the trash.

Ritual

Early in June sometime.

way after lunch on a Sunday / acherage

The neighbours are out dethatching their
front lawns.

Picking away at the soggy twigs.

I don't recall ever bending over
that many times—

the blue-eyes
always
preferring a little debris.

Low-End Jags

Early in January sometime.

6:34 a.m. on a Monday / sleeping beauty.

Today there is no Belvedere—
no highway.

A no-name fob replacement dies
again
for the umpteenth time in sub-zero temps.

I'm on the phone with
Phil—the vehicle repair rep.
He knows the policy,
knows the car.

He says it's the control module.

A foot of snow in the drive.
The bay window—hi-def in wide format.

Accolades at the Nor-Am Cup in Tremblant—
cascading down the mountainside

Toggling
not an option.

Up There on the Pedometer

Mid May sometime.

5:30 a.m. on a Tuesday / an elephant
is an elephant

I turn right, up my pace.

The early rains come unannounced.

A plate not on the menu
at from yesterday—still sits with me
this morning.

I walk it off.

Ms. Figaro

Much later in December sometime.

10:05 a.m. on a Friday / let me cut your mop

I turn right—to St. Laurent Mall.

Today

the senior's discount came fully announced.

I think it was that young thing cutting someone
else's hair.

smiling back at me in the mirror.

Bestowal

Later in September sometime.

8:15 a.m. on a Friday / back pedaling.

A few cracks in the sacroiliac—possibly the ego.

A slightly used e-bike rattles back and forth
on a detachable Thule—

a wildlife relocation of sorts.

from me to yous.

Full Circle

The middle of July sometime.

7:30 a.m. on a Monday / warping

Today I test my e-bike,

turn left, follow the course on

Tucker Road at the end of David Street—

chase the back nine.

In the rearview: DriFits, Polos.

Absorber shocks.

I re-enter Belvedere Avenue,

dial up to third.

Mike from across the street—outside

putting the big knobbies on his 4x4.

He refers to me as the old guy.

The shih poos have no opinion.

I Rest My Case

Early in May sometime.

11:00 a.m. on a Thursday / in the eyes of the
beholder

Today again—window bound, an invasion
of a better class of weeds—the familiar blue-eyes.

The battle was lost a season ago when the grubs
ate away at the roots.

Last year's bag of grass seed
still slouching against the shed

a wrinkle in the torso maybe,
smiling back—airtight.

nolo contendere.

Island on the Floe

In February sometime.

9:05 a.m. on a Saturday / follies

Today I turn right,
in search of nothing more than a jiggling line
from a snow-tethered shack.

Not far from Barney's Stone

I set up shop.

A couple of seabirds tip-toe from
shuga to shuga.

little interest in the shear.

Artifice

Early in June sometime.

11:05 a.m. on a Tuesday / out in the yard

I travel past the last Moodie turn-off sign.

Turn into the drive—the red-tail of a fox
flashes by the shed out back.

It meant there was a coop nearby—
and Todd—a cohort of sorts.

The young chicks
unaware of course,
how senses run amok
long after the final
cut.

how the smaller twigs
might snap—
outside the chicken wire.

In Vogue

Early in June sometime.

10:00 a.m. on a Saturday / tuber

Today again—no walk down the bike path—
not even laundry.

It's the drizzle. It comes and goes.

I am in hi-def and wide format.

A rerun of Ant-Man and the Wasp is playing.

The protagonist shrinks the lab
to the size of a man purse.

Wears it like Gucci.

Walks away like nothing happened.

The list of credits a mile long.

Escape to Mars

Early in June sometime.

10:00 a.m. on a Saturday / repeat tuber

Today I am wide and in hi-def again—
somewhere between a remake of Soylent Green
and an iRobot-omy as a Roomba knocks
against my chair.

And CNN insists we'll all profit from water-cooled
deep thought—

Degrassi's kiss, SoftBot phone sex with
realistic lips—tomorrow's church—Truth Social—likely intervening.

And you won't need an education just a
helmet—the latest fad is MOABs.

I'd double check with Gandhi's website—
but roughly that's all seven.

The BBQ Pit

In May toward the end.

8:00 a.m. on a Saturday / out back

Today, there is no departure

just submission—almost Hallmark.

The hyacinths so thick they seem almost

self-extinguishing.

And I am thankful for the humor, the introspection,

the lack of rhyme.

The hallelujahs I could do without.

The creaking and moaning of a backyard

apparatus.

As before

the rest hanging in the cedars, a row out back

that unrelents.

Where teacups and other fine breeds

lift legs purely out of habit.

I retreat from a grille that slowly burns

this Canadian kabob.

Hoping the CO won't attract more microscopic drills

and other airborne things.

I slap my wrist.

Keep the zapper on.

The ZERO Agenda

The Zero Agenda gathers a series of observational poems set largely in and around Ottawa, Canada. Part travelogue, part notebook, part ongoing investigation, these poems find meaning not in grand events but in the overlooked details of everyday life: a crowded church parking lot, a pharmacy run, a neighbor's dog, a patch of wildflowers, a turn taken for no particular reason.

Written in a voice that is by turns wry, reflective, and quietly amused, the collection follows a speaker who treats the smallest incidents as worthy of attention. The clues are often tiny, the stakes modest, yet the impulse to observe remains constant. What emerges is a portrait of place, habit, aging, curiosity, and the peculiar dramas hidden within ordinary days.

Bernard Alain is a Canadian poet whose work explores memory, landscape, family, and the overlooked corners of everyday experience. He lives in Ottawa, where many of the roads, rivers, parking lots, and side streets that populate these poems continue to provide material for further investigation.

The Zero Agenda

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